

Assignment 5: Additional Vital Sign Report- Ansarah Mohammed

Vital Sign Chosen, which should be included: Oxygen Saturation (SpO₂)

The vital sign or measure I believe should be included in triage is oxygen saturation, also known as SpO₂. Oxygen saturation measures how much oxygen is being carried by the blood as a percentage. It is usually measured using a pulse oximeter, which is a small clip-like device placed on the finger. This is important because the body needs oxygen for organs such as the brain, heart, and lungs to function properly. If oxygen levels become too low, the body may not work properly, and the patient may need urgent care (MedlinePlus, 2024).

The normal clinical range for oxygen saturation is usually 95% to 100% in healthy individuals (Pesola & Sankari, 2023; MedlinePlus, 2024). A reading below this range may suggest that the patient is not getting enough oxygen. MedlinePlus states that an oxygen saturation of 92% or lower should be discussed with a healthcare provider, while 88% or lower may require immediate medical attention (MedlinePlus, 2024). However, oxygen saturation must also be interpreted based on the patient's condition, because some patients with chronic lung diseases such as COPD may normally have slightly lower oxygen levels.

For triaging, oxygen saturation is very useful because it can quickly show whether a patient may be in respiratory distress or at risk of deterioration. For example, a patient with a low SpO₂, shortness of breath, chest pain, confusion, or bluish lips may need to be seen urgently. In emergency triage, a low oxygen saturation can cause a patient to be moved to a higher priority level, especially if it is combined with other abnormal signs such as a high respiratory rate or fever. This makes SpO₂ important because it gives a quick warning that the patient's oxygen supply may not be enough for the body.

Overall, I think oxygen saturation should be included in the triage dataset because it gives important information that blood pressure, MAP, heart rate, or GCS alone may not show. A patient can have normal blood pressure but still have dangerously low oxygen levels. Including SpO₂ would make triage more complete because it helps identify patients with breathing problems, lung infections, asthma attacks, heart failure, or other serious conditions earlier.

References

MedlinePlus. (2024, September 12). *Pulse oximetry*. U.S. National Library of Medicine.
<https://medlineplus.gov/lab-tests/pulse-oximetry/>

Pesola, G. R., & Sankari, A. (2023). *Oxygenation status and pulse oximeter analysis*. In *StatPearls*. StatPearls Publishing. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK592401/>

Emergency Severity Index Handbook Fifth Edition. (n.d.). *Emergency Severity Index handbook*.
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